

BRAVEHOOD

THEMATIC CONSTITUTION

The rules that decide what this game is about — and the test every system, every asset and every cue must pass before it ships.

SECOND EDITION • THE THREE DUNGEONS

SANATORIUM • CISTERNS • MIRRORGLACIER

01

The Thesis

A game about virtue cannot be a game that talks about virtue. It has to be a game that charges you for it.

Bravehood is built in three layers. Each one must work completely on its own, for a player who never notices the layer above it.

LAYER	WHAT IT IS	WHO SEES IT
Surface	A tense, excellent PvPvE extraction crawler. Combat that feels good, loot worth dying for, dungeons worth learning.	Everyone. Non-negotiable.
Thematic	Every system quietly asks one question: <i>what do you owe a stranger when it costs you something?</i>	Most players, eventually - felt, not read.
Authorial	Three figures who each removed something painful about being human, and removed the human with it. They are the player's own optimisation, given time and authority.	The ones who go looking. Never explained.

The order matters. Layer one is the contract with the player; layers two and three are ours. If depth is ever bought by making the game less fun, it has failed on its own terms - a lesson nobody stays to learn.

**Virtue is only real when it is expensive.
Our genre makes everything expensive. That is the whole
opportunity.**

Scarcity, permadeath and rival players already exist in this game. They are not obstacles to a moral story - they are the only conditions under which one can be told. In most games helping is free, so it means nothing. Here, reviving a stranger costs time, exposure and possibly the run. That cost is the asset. Protect it.

02

Method

Four working rules. They decide arguments.

1. The surface must satisfy on its own

The Shining works as a haunted-house film for a viewer who never thinks about it again. Bravehood must work as an extraction crawler for a player who never notices a theme. Depth is a second layer, never a substitute for the first.

2. Never state the thesis

Build the system, then let the player convict themselves. A game that tells players that mercy matters earns an eye-roll. A game that lets them be selfish and then quietly shows them what they became earns an essay. We do not write a moral. We build the conditions under which the player writes one.

No villain explains himself. No document tells the player what a room meant. If the meaning cannot survive without a lore entry, the meaning is in the wrong place - move it into architecture, light, animation, sound or a system.

3. Beauty carries the horror

Bravehood does not compete on gore. Blood is cheap, and visual noise is the fastest way to make a frightening place boring. Our strongest horror is elegant, calm, ordered, immaculate and seductive - a monstrous idea delivered gorgeously.

The test is simple: **the player should sometimes want to look at the thing that ought to disturb them.** This governs the Veil everywhere and the Mirroglacier Gallery almost entirely. Atrocity scored with grace is unbearable, and it lasts. Ugliness scored with ugliness is merely loud.

4. The player must be allowed to fail the theme

If cruelty is impossible, kindness is not a choice - it is a corridor. The option to be worse is what makes being better mean anything. We do not protect players from their own behaviour, and we never punish it with a system that announces itself.

03

The World Doctrine

One idea holds the world together. It must never be spoken aloud inside the game.

**Every dungeon begins with something humanity built to protect or enrich itself.
Each shows that virtue optimised until the human being becomes unnecessary.**

DUNGEON	BEGAN AS	BECAME	THE HUMAN ENDS AS
The Black Veil Sanatorium	Care	Treatment, then processing	Material
The Cisterns of the Veiled Oracle	Order	Prediction, then certainty	Function
The Mirroglacier Gallery	Beauty	Preservation, then perfection	Object

None of these began in cruelty. A hospital that wanted to end suffering. An order that wanted to spare people their worst decisions. A gallery that wanted beauty to survive us. Each is a virtue, and each is followed past the point where a person would have stopped.

The Veil is not corruption

It would be easy and wrong to treat the Veil as evil energy staining good places. The Veil is an **amplifier**. It lets a human idea continue beyond the point at which a human being would normally lose the will, the years or the nerve to continue it. It supplies no motive of its own. Everything terrible in this world was wanted by somebody, for reasons they could defend.

That is why the Veil is beautiful rather than diseased, and why it grows more ordered as it grows stronger. It is not rot. It is a good idea pursued without mercy.

This page states the doctrine plainly because this is an internal document. In the game it is never stated at all - it is only ever built.

04

The Visual Lexicon

Art direction is not decoration in this project. Light is the moral language of the game, and it is the first thing the player reads.

Semantic meaning is global. Physical expression is local.

The same four ideas run through every dungeon. What changes is the fixture, the material and the century - never the meaning. A green medical lantern is Sanatorium dialect, not the definition of an institution.

CATEGORY	MEANS	LIGHTING LANGUAGE
Humanity	Care, habitation, imperfection. Somebody was here, and decided something.	Warm, irregular, hand-placed, localised, slightly inconsistent. It should look chosen, not installed.
Institution	Order without intimacy. A system that outlived the people it served.	Repeated, evenly spaced, predictable, architectural rather than personal. Placed by policy.
The Veil	A human idea continuing past its author.	Spectral turquoise and teal, with restrained violet only as refraction or fringe. Cold, geometric, seductive, increasingly ordered.
Desire	What the player wants, as opposed to what they owe.	Hot white-gold. Reserved absolutely for loot, extraction, rare objectives and major interactable rewards.

Warm light is what you owe; white-gold is what you want. Once the two are never confused, the player learns to feel the difference between a room that cared for someone and a prize that does not care about them at all - and they learn it without a line of text.

Historical gold is not desire. A Renaissance frame, an Ottoman brass fitting, a gilded carving may all be muted, aged or tarnished gold as *material*. They must never emit the hot white-gold light that means *take this*.

The Veil is earned, not sprinkled. Crystal is not fantasy decoration. If a crystal or a strong Veil emission appears in a room, it is making a statement, and someone should be able to say what it is. Keep supernatural elements rare on the first floor of every dungeon and let them take the architecture over as the player descends.

The lighting rule

No visually unmotivated lighting. Bravehood may use restrained bounce, global illumination, atmospheric fog and deliberate readability light - for enemy silhouettes, combat telegraphs, traversal, PvP legibility and interactable recognition. Readability is not a compromise with the theme; it is the surface layer, and the surface layer wins.

What is forbidden is light the fiction cannot explain. The player must always believe the light belongs to the room. Dark environments, never unreadable ones.

The question to ask of any room stays the same: **who lit this, and why did they stop?**

Geometry is language

Our low and mid-poly direction is not a production limit dressed as a style. It is the thesis expressed in polygons. Human-made space is irregular, asymmetric, worn, repaired, cluttered, softened by use. Veil-influenced space is repetitive, perfectly aligned, faceted, crystalline, impossibly symmetrical.

The world therefore travels **from imperfect human geometry toward beautiful inhuman geometry**. A player who never thinks about any of this still feels the floor turn against them.

05

The Human Baseline

Before showing what was lost, establish what existed.

This is a production rule, and the one most often broken. If every room opens already corrupted, ominous and abandoned, the dungeon has nowhere left to travel and the horror flattens into set dressing. Loss requires something to lose.

Every dungeon opens with strong evidence of ordinary human purpose: people worked here, slept here, ate here, cared about something here. Then, floor by floor, we take it away.

REMOVE, PROGRESSIVELY	INTRODUCE, PROGRESSIVELY
Comfort, clutter, personal belongings	Repetition and symmetry
Asymmetry and evidence of individual choice	Abstraction and supernatural geometry
Human-scale architecture and sightlines	Impossible scale and unnatural precision
Signs of maintenance, repair and habit	Architectural indifference to human bodies

**The deepest spaces should not look more evil.
They should feel less interested in human beings.**

Recognition

Recognising another person as a person is the central moral act of this game, and the art must protect it. The rule is not that every enemy looks human - it is that **anything that was once human must keep enough humanity to be recognised as having once been someone**.

One clear signal is enough: recognisable clothing, a human hand, a familiar posture, the tools of a former trade, a personal object still carried, a human sound. That single detail is what makes killing it cost something. Creatures that were never human are under no such obligation and may be as strange as the fiction allows.

Silhouette readability for gameplay is separate and absolute. Every enemy must read instantly at distance, in fog and in shadow, whatever it has become.

DUNGEON	WHAT PEOPLE ARE TURNED INTO
Sanatorium	Material and instruments - bodies treated as supply.
Cisterns	Roles and functions - guard, watcher, messenger, executioner. The person is gone; the post remains.
Mirrorglacier	Exhibits and objects - arranged, lit, and perfectly still.

06

Dungeon Dialects

How each place speaks the shared language. Constitutional, not an art bible - the detail belongs in each dungeon's own documentation.

The Black Veil Sanatorium

Quarantine Wards › Alchemical Theatre › Mass-Burial Crypts. The body against optimisation.

- **Human baseline.** Beds, cloth, bedside objects, belongings, small hearths, worn oil lamps. Someone sat with someone here.
- **Institution.** Regulated green medical lanterns, repetition, medical apparatus, procedural architecture that moves bodies efficiently.
- **Veil dialect.** Alchemy, then unnatural growth, then crystalline replacement of flesh and fixture alike.
- **Progression.** Human care › institutional processing › architecture no longer designed for people at all.

The horror here is medicine without compassion. Care became treatment, treatment became processing, and the patient became supply.

The Cisterns of the Veiled Oracle

Columned Cistern › Fortress Quarters and Courtyard › Veiled Court. Choice against certainty.

- **Human baseline.** Engineering and habitation - soldiers, workers, water infrastructure, brass lamps, tools, cloth, the practical clutter of a place that was run.
- **Institution.** Repeating columns, regimented lamps between them, controlled guard positions, symmetrical barracks, prescribed routes.
- **Veil dialect.** Water, reflection and stillness. Suspended fabrics, turquoise geometry beneath the surface, impossible alignments, sightlines that feel arranged for an observer who is not you.
- **Progression.** Human engineering › controlled order › architecture built around prophecy rather than around people.

The deeper the player travels, the more rooms appear designed to observe, predict and position human beings rather than accommodate them. Nothing here is medical, and nothing here is borrowed from the Sanatorium - this dungeon must never read as the same building with different props.

The Mirrorglacier Gallery

Gallery Halls › Fresco Vaults › Prism Arena. Imperfection against perfection.

- **Human baseline.** Artists and restorers - benches, brushes, unfinished work, workshop lamps, frames waiting to be filled. Evidence of people who loved this.

- **Institution.** Formal museum order, symmetrical display, standardised lighting designed to present objects rather than comfort visitors.
- **Veil dialect.** Cold crystalline preservation, turquoise spectral refraction, perfect geometry, rooms growing more immaculate and more motionless.
- **Progression.** Appreciation › preservation › perfect composition › a gallery in which a living person is visual contamination.

This is not an ice dungeon. It remains, unmistakably, a prestigious Renaissance gallery - and that is the horror: a beautiful place so perfectly kept that the living no longer belong inside it. Avoid shattered-mirror clutter, beams and generic frost fantasy. The cold is preservation, not weather.

07

The Musical Lexicon

Fixed meanings, never broken. Players learn this vocabulary subconsciously in about four hours of play.

The score carries the same semantics as the light: global meaning, local expression. What an instrument *means* is settled here. Which instrument says it belongs to the dungeon.

MEANING	ITS ROLE IN THE SCORE
The individual soul	One fragile, breakable voice. Mechanical rather than expressive - something that can stop.
A person	A single bowed line. Breathing, mortal, singular.
The collective	Massed voices. Humanity in the plural.
The institution	A drone. It continues regardless of anyone.
Authority	One instrument large enough to fill the room alone.
The Veil	Tuned, glassy, and slightly too perfect to be played by hands.
Labour	Ritual percussion. The machinery of the place.

Dialect

MEANING	SANATORIUM	CISTERNS	MIRRORGLACIER
Individual	Music box	A single struck bowl over water	Celesta, glass
A person	Solo cello	Solo bowed spike fiddle	Solo viol
Collective	Women's choir	Low chant in unison	Renaissance polyphony
Institution	Hurdy-gurdy drone	Sustained ison drone	Sustained consort chord
Authority	Church organ	Vast resonant space itself	Harpsichord, exact
The Veil	Glass armonica	Reflected, reversed sound	Crystal, perfect intervals

Each dungeon keeps its own key, its own tempo and its own room - one convolution space per location, never one for the whole game. Three dungeons must not sound like three wings of the same building. Within a dungeon, the constraint is absolute: one tempo, one key, one room, so any two stems can be layered and the

place sounds like a place.

The grammar

The instruments carry the nouns. The voice-leading carries the argument, and it never changes between dungeons:

**Unison is solidarity. Harmony is cooperation.
Dissonance is betrayal. Solo is isolation.**

This is a claim about what people owe each other, stated in the only language that reaches a player without asking permission.

08

The Moral Mirror

The score already runs on layered stems. That system can be pointed at the player instead of the encounter.

Observe tendencies, never verdicts. Extraction games produce ambiguous situations constantly - a player who runs from a fight they could not win has done nothing wrong, and a single killing tells us nothing. What we watch is the shape a player's behaviour takes across dozens of hours.

SIGNALS WORTH WATCHING	WHAT NEVER HAPPENS
Revives given, and at what risk. Abandonment. Shared extraction. Cooperation with strangers. Predation on the clearly helpless. Repeated betrayal. Willingness to accept personal cost for someone else.	No notification. No meter. No score. No use of the words good, evil, karma or reputation - internally or in the build.

Over time, the mix drifts. A player who helps hears the collective move toward **unison**; a second voice joins the solo line. A player who preys hears the collective **fracture**, voices fall away, and eventually only the solo line is left. The individual motif holds its tuning, or slowly loses it.

It must move slowly enough that it can never be reverse-engineered inside a session, reproduced on demand, or farmed. If a player can make the music change on purpose, the system is broken and should be slowed until they cannot.

Announce none of it. A visible meter turns this into a score to optimise; an invisible one turns it into a mirror. The difference between those two outcomes is the entire project. The intended discovery, arriving late and alone, is: *the game has been describing how I behave.*

Implementation note: a persistent tendency biasing existing stem weights - not new audio, not a new system, and never a per-run judgement.

09

The Three Conclusions

The antagonists are not monsters. They are conclusions.

FIGURE	OPTIMISES	REMOVES	AND SO REMOVES
The Doctor	The body	Suffering, by correcting human imperfection	The person
The Oracle	Choice	Uncertainty, by knowing the correct future	The freedom to be wrong
The Curator	Beauty	Decay, by stopping change entirely	The living

They are not a council. They share no organisation, no correspondence and no plan, and they should never appear to. Their connection is philosophical: each is a different version of the same danger, which is **optimisation without mercy**.

Each is also, in his or her own terms, right. The Doctor really can end suffering. The Oracle really does know the safer road. The Curator really has saved what would otherwise be lost. Their arguments must be strong enough that a reasonable player feels the pull before they feel the horror. A villain the player never agrees with is decoration.

Stated in music, never in dialogue

- **The Doctor** takes the player's own theme, harmonised correctly: clean voice-leading, full cadence, no dissonance, perfectly in tune. Beautiful, and *finished*. The player's version stays broken and unresolved. Perfection is the horror; resolution is the horror.
- **The Oracle** takes the same theme as a strict canon - the answer arrives before the question, every phrase already anticipated. Music that knows what happens next, and is never once surprised.
- **The Curator** takes it and stops it: a chord that never moves, immaculate, held beyond endurance. Nothing decays because nothing is permitted to change.

None of them explains this. There are no monologues in Bravehood.

The player performs their philosophy in miniature dozens of times an hour, and calls it a good run.

Stripping bodies for parts. Deciding whose survival is worth the cost. Reducing a stranger to what they are carrying. The three figures have simply been consistent about it for longer, and had the Veil to keep them going. That is the deepest connection between this world and its gameplay, and the player must be allowed to find it alone.

10

Mechanics Doctrine

Rules for designers. These are the systems that carry the argument.

- **Make helping cost.** Reviving takes real time in the open. Carrying a wounded stranger slows you. Both of you live, or you leave them - and you know which one you chose.
- **Cooperation redistributes cost; it never gates progress.** Two players can work a mechanism safely. One player can always solve it too - slower, louder, at greater risk, by spending a resource, by giving something up, by standing exposed. The theme is *another person can help carry this*, never *this game requires two accounts*.

- **Leadership means bearing consequence.** Let one player commit the group to a route or an objective, and let the cost of being wrong land on them. Not a bigger icon - a heavier one.
- **Let the player see what they cost someone.** The value of what you took should be legible from the other side. Anonymity is what makes predation cheap.

Never reward virtue with loot.

This is the rule most likely to be broken by accident, and breaking it is fatal. The moment mercy pays better than cruelty, mercy stops being mercy and becomes the optimal build. Players will farm it, streamers will chart it, and within a patch cycle the game's moral centre is a spreadsheet column.

ALLOWED - EMERGENT CONSEQUENCE	FORBIDDEN - ISSUED REWARD
Someone you saved defends you. A pair clears a room more safely than one. Information gets shared. A burden is split. Someone remembers you next week.	Virtue XP. Morality currency. Karma tiers. Better loot tables for helping. Any counter, anywhere, that a player could aim at.

The distinction is authorship. A consequence that arises between players is the world working. A reward handed down by us is a price list, and players read price lists correctly and immediately.

Virtue must remain **economically irrational and emotionally undeniable**. Pay it in currencies that cannot be optimised: how the score changes, what the world lets you see, what other players remember you for. Those cannot be farmed, because wanting them for their own sake is the virtue.

11

The Test

Run every room, asset, system, cue and enemy against this page before it ships.

ASK	FAIL CONDITION
Does this work for a player who never notices the theme?	If it only makes sense as a message, it is not a game feature.
Does it remain readable and enjoyable as a PvPvE extraction game?	If ambition damages combat, navigation or readability, the surface layer wins. Always.
What human purpose did this originally serve?	No answer means decorative fantasy architecture. Give it a use, or cut it.
How has that purpose been distorted?	The distortion must express <i>this</i> dungeon's problem - body, choice or decay.
Is this supernatural element saying something?	If the crystal is there because crystals look good, remove or redesign it.
Is this global language or dungeon dialect?	Meaning is global; fixtures, materials and instruments are local. Confusing the two makes three dungeons into one.
Does the deeper version become less human, or merely busier?	Prefer loss of humanity over added decoration. Emptier and colder beats louder.

ASK	FAIL CONDITION
Would the player understand what matters without reading lore?	If not, move the meaning into light, architecture, animation, sound or a system.
Does it state the message out loud?	If a character explains the moral, cut the line and keep the system.
Does virtue cost something here?	If helping is free, it means nothing. Add a price.
Is virtue being paid in loot?	If yes, it will be farmed. Change the currency.
Can the player choose to be worse?	If not, the good choice is a corridor, not a choice.
Does the light belong to the room?	Readability light is permitted; unmotivated light is not. The fiction must explain the room.
Does the cue obey the lexicon and the grammar?	Breaking a fixed meaning costs us every hour the player spent learning it.

This document decides arguments. When two good ideas conflict, the one that satisfies the surface layer wins - and if they both do, the one that makes the player pay for something they believe in wins. Everything else is negotiable; this is not.